Where Shadows Dwell

by Rhea Markos



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MUSES. Long ago in Ancient Greece, gods rose and fell according to the whims of Zeus. Oh, Mighty Zeus, god of the sky who defeated the monstrous titans and ruled over the earth. Oh, Terrible Mighty Zeus, who took whatever he wanted, whenever he wanted. Goddesses and mortal women lived in fear: his love was pain, but his wrath was ruin. And when she came of age, there was one whom Zeus wanted above all others…the goddess Persephone.

PERSEPHONE. Help!

MUSES. She was beautiful, but naive. She was loving, but rebellious. She was a goddess and a fool.

PERSEPHONE. Please! Who does a goddess pray to? I have nothing and no one to ask for help. Everything alive serves him. Everything on earth. There's nowhere to hide…

MUSES. Unless…

PERSEPHONE. Unless…I've heard stories about another world…

MUSES. An underworld.

PERSEPHONE. And a lord of the dead…

MUSES. Hades…

PERSEPHONE. It's my only chance. Please, Hades. Save me.

In the Encyclopedia of Feminism, Lisa Tuttle explains that revisionist mythmaking, or the retelling of stories to feature strong female heroines, is crucial to the reinterpretation of how we see women in society. She suggests that for every narrative where the damsel isn't distressed, we create a stronger sense of equality and further the idea that choice, not gender, as the ultimate determinant of success. In this retelling of the Greek myth of Persephone, the goddess is not helplessly seduced by a pomegranate or the victim of kidnap by the god Hades. Instead she seeks freedom from an oppressive patriarch by learning that even in the darkness there is light. Where Shadows Dwell *by Rhea Markos.*

PERSEPHONE. What happened? Where am I? Where is the light?

HADES. Give your eyes a chance to adjust.

PERSEPHONE. Who is that? Who's there?

HADES. The one you called for.

PERSEPHONE. You're Hades?

HADES. I am.

PERSEPHONE. But you're a woman…

HADES. So your eyes are adjusting after all. Here, let me help you up. I'm not going to hurt you.

PERSEPHONE. I'm sorry. I've heard stories about the lord of the underworld.

HADES. Yes. I'm sure you've heard that I am evil, cruel, and *a man*. Obviously it's not all true.

PERSEPHONE. That doesn't mean none of it is.

HADES. I rescued you, didn't I? Brought you somewhere safe.

PERSEPHONE. To the land of the dead?

HADES. If it is not suited to your liking, you are free to go!

PERSEPHONE. No, I didn't mean…I'm sorry. I am still in shock.

HADES. And I am out of practice in the ways of civility. You called for my

help. What do you need?

PERSEPHONE. Zeus means to take me with him to Olympus.

HADES. And you do not want to live with the gods on Olympus? To be in Zeus's favor?

PERSEPHONE. To be a plaything? No.

HADES. So you wish to stay?

PERSEPHONE. I have nowhere else to go.

HADES. I'll prepare a room for you and you can rest. Tomorrow, I will show you around the underworld, your new home.

PERSEPHONE. My new home…

MUSES. So Persephone gave up a gilded cage on high, for an unknown world below. And while Zeus hunted for her, Persephone began her new life in the dark. Days passed, and Persephone began to see the Underworld as Hades saw it. Not as a place of death, but as a place for the lost.

HADES. Is your room to your liking? Did you sleep well?

PERSEPHONE. Like the dead. It was a joke.

HADES. Yes. Forgive me, I… I haven't heard laughter in long time. It's lovely. Now, as long as you are here, you must follow the rules. The Underworld is not like where you come from. There are dangers here that you must avoid.

PERSEPHONE. Dangers? I'm immortal.

HADES. Yes, a god will not die from natural causes. But in the land of the dead, there are unnatural causes. And if you die here, you're trapped forever.

PERSEPHONE. Aren't I already trapped here?

HADES. What?

PERSEPHONE. I mean, I can't leave. This is the only place I can hide from Zeus. So I'm pretty much powerless either way: it's his prison or yours.

HADES. Your life is now—as it has always been—your choice. You are not my prisoner. And you are not powerless. So many gods think that others give you power or the fates make your choices. Those are lies. Believe me—as a god whom no one has ever built an altar for, and as one who has seen all fates—I promise you, the only true powers in this world are choice and belief in yourself. And you have already proven yourself to be very powerful.

PERSEPHONE. You are not what I expected, Hades.

HADES. Yes, I hear that a lot.

PERSEPHONE. Why do they call you a lord? Why do mortals think you are a man?

HADES. A lie spread by Zeus. My brother. He taunts me because I prefer the company of women.

PERSEPHONE. Oh? Oh.

HADES. It's not just me. Zeus spreads lies about most gods to make himself more powerful. He is believed only because he is the king of Olympus.

PERSEPHONE. Plus, he can change his form to look like anyone or anything to

get what he wants.

HADES. Indeed. I could be Zeus right now.

PERSEPHONE. Or I could be, and you'd never know.

HADES. I would know it wasn't you. Zeus can transform outer appearance, but he can never mimic inner beauty.

PERSEPHONE. Thank you. Do you think he will discover where I've gone?

HADES. Perhaps, eventually.

PERSEPHONE. So I'll never be free. I'll never go home. I'll never feel the grass or or see the night sky or taste a pomegranate. I'm sorry, I don't mean to be ungrateful.

HADES. Not at all. I am more familiar with grief than most. I only wish I could offer you some comfort.

PERSEPHONE. You have.

MUSES. In the world above, whispers of Persephone's whereabouts had reached Zeus. The sky shook with his fury. But far below and unaware, Hades and Persephone grew closer… Because the only way to see in the dark is with your heart.

PERSEPHONE. What is this place?

HADES. A surprise. A new addition to the Underworld. I created it to host the wisps of ancient souls. Those who have been gone so long, they forgot their bodies and all that's left is their inner light.

PERSEPHONE. It looks…

HADES. Like the night sky. Yes. I got the idea from you. And the wisps have yet one more surprise. If you dance for them, they sing. (*offers a hand*)

PERSEPHONE. But who will lead?

HADES. We will take turns.

PERSEPHONE. This place is incredible.

HADES. The Underworld can be beautiful, if you are willing to see beneath the darkness.

PERSEPHONE. I'm beginning to understand.

HADES. I have a gift for you. A necklace.

PERSEPHONE. Made from pomegranate seeds?

HADES. You said you missed them.

PERSEPHONE. It's beautiful. It reminds me of…

HADES. Your home? I'm sorry, I thought it would make you happy.

PERSEPHONE. Yes. No. I don't know. It's wonderful. I'll cherish it.

HADES. Persephone? What's wrong?

PERSEPHONE. Nothing. It's just…I came here to escape from Zeus.

HADES. I know.

PERSEPHONE. It's why I came. It's not why I stayed. Do you understand? Hades? What was that noise?

HADES. An alarm. Something's happened. Stay here.

PERSEPHONE. I will…

HADES/ZEUS. Persephone.

PERSEPHONE. What's happened?

HADES/ZEUS. It's Zeus. He's discovered where you are. He'll be here any moment. He's coming to take you and kill me. You have to come with me now.

PERSEPHONE. I don't understand. Why would we leave the Underworld?

HADES/ZEUS. He's too strong. Too powerful. Come on.

PERSEPHONE. You're hurting me.

HADES/ZEUS. I'm sorry, I forget how strong I am. I just, I care so much about you.

PERSEPHONE. You do?

HADES/ZEUS. Of course I do! You are as precious to me as…as that old necklace is to you.

PERSEPHONE. What?

HADES/ZEUS. That necklace, I assume it's old because it's hideous. A gift from that terrible mother of yours, not doubt.

PERSEPHONE. "He can transform outer appearance, but he can never mimic inner beauty."

HADES/ZEUS. What did you say, child?

PERSEPHONE. Nice try, Zeus.

HADES/ZEUS. *(whole face and demeanor changes from concern to pure evil as Zeus is revealed)* Oh, Persephone. Beautiful and clever. You will make such a fine addition to my Olympus.

PERSEPHONE. What have you done with Hades?

HADES/ZEUS. Never mind that now. You've got more important things to worry about.

PERSEPHONE. I'm not going with you.

HADES/ZEUS. As if it were up to you? As if you had the power to stop it? Give me what I want, or I will take it.

PERSEPHONE. I'd like to see you try.

HADES/ZEUS. What? What is this? Night sky, I command you!

PERSEPHONE. It's not the sky. It's an illusion. And without the sky you have no lightning or thunder to frighten me with.

HADES/ZEUS. Then we'll do this the old fashioned way.

(They fight. She captures him with the necklace around her throat.)

PERSEPHONE. Yield, Zeus!

HADES/ZEUS. Or what? You foolish girl, I'm immortal!

PERSEPHONE. Yes, a god will not die from natural causes. But in the land of the dead, there are unnatural causes. And if you die here, you're trapped forever. Yield.

HADES/ZEUS. Very well. I yield.

PERSEPHONE. Now tell me where Hades is.

MUSES. Persephone ran through the Forest of the Immortals. And even though she once again saw the sky and her beloved pomegranate trees, her eyes were fixed for one thing only.

PERSEPHONE. Hades!

HADES. Persephone. It was Zeus. He's coming for you.

PERSEPHONE. All is well. He is gone. He's left us.

HADES. You're free?

PERSEPHONE. We both are. Free and together.

HADES. Our story—our true story—will never be known, Persephone. Zeus's lies will take root, and they will spread. They will believe that I…took you, kidnapped you…

PERSEPHONE. I am free, Hades. As I have been every moment I've been with you. Our story will be here for those who are willing to see beneath the darkness. That you saved me.

HADES. And then you saved me.

PERSEPHONE. We took turns.

MUSES. And so Persephone and her dark wife Hades disappeared into the Underworld. They chose one another and found true freedom.